learned about my illness, but I was comforted and helped by the solidarity expressed by the Chilean people, by friends and fellow-men throughout the world. I never thought I would see my dear wife and brave companion again.

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After reiterating his thanks, he was taken to Las Condes Hospital to undergo new medical check-ups and treatment for his kidney cancer. The following day he arrived at his last address – 'House G' on Carlos Silva Vildósola – a small two-floor residence in the condominium of La Reina.

The walls were beige, the furniture plain and simple – a blue-white-red striped sofa, glass table, wicker chair and a sideboard. A large fuchsia bougainvillea stood out in a garden, full of untidy bushes and clothes drying in the sun.

Without skipping a beat, Margot took full control of her husband's care, coordinating his medicine, fixing meals, maintaining finances and scheduling visitors. She hired Diego Aguirre as a live-in secretary to act as an interpreter and personal assistant. From then on, 22-year-old Aguirre – a former exile in East Berlin – helped his new master deal with doctors, translate private discussions, and aid with mail.3 In those first few weeks, Aguirre was bewildered by the constant surveillance from the German media – only inside, behind closed drapes, was the family hidden from the glare of photographers. Erich was happiest when Sonja and the grandchildren came to visit. 'He wanted to spend his last days with his family,' Aguirre recalled. 'That was the most important thing for him. In those moments he was happy and smiled.'4 Far from being bored, Honecker devoured the German press, which always arrived with a two-day delay, while Aguirre translated articles from local newspapers. More than anything else, however, Honecker committed himself to organising his memoirs, a colossal effort that never gained traction given his preoccupation with listening to the tides and currents of German opinion via shortwave radio, and turning on the rhetoric, full flood, in defence of